



Mandarin -lǎo: A Case of Analytic Pejorativity

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Overview

Evaluative morphology has been noted in generative linguistics since Scalise (1984). It expresses two dimensions of meaning, one objective, and one subjective (RITTER & WILTSCHKO 2023).

This paper studies the morphosyntax of the Mandarin pejorative suffix -lǎo (佬), glossed as PEJ, which is a case of evaluative morphology.

- -lǎo attaches to a stem and yields a noun;
- the noun typically denotes adult males (objective meaning, at issue) while carrying pejorative effects (subjective meaning, non-at issue), e.g. (1);
- While in some regions, -lǎo is neutral, we focus only on variants that have -lǎo as pejorative.

(1) X shì yí gè jī-lǎo.
NAME COP one CL gay-PEJ
At issue: 'X is a gay man.'
Non-at issue: '(The speaker thinks that) gay people in general/ gayness is bad.'

Properties of -lǎo

Morphosyntactic properties:

- -lǎo can attach to noun-, verb- or adjective-forming stems (2);
- yet -lǎo normally does not attach to occupation-denoting stems (3);
- -lǎo is always dependent — it cannot be used alone as a noun (4).

(2) Stem _(N/V/A) -lǎo	Gloss	Translation
n ¹ xiāngbā-lǎo	countryside-PEJ	(pej.) man from the countryside (hillbilly)
n ² jīnróng-lǎo	finance-PEJ	(pej.) men in finance
v ¹ [diào-yú]-lǎo	[catch-fish]-PEJ	(pej.) fisherman/ man who fishes a lot
v ² [hé-shì]-lǎo	[mediate-thing]-PEJ	(pej.) peacemaker
a. féi-lǎo	fat-PEJ	(pej.) fat man

(3)a* [lǎo-shī]-lǎo	b* [gē-shǒu]-lǎo	c* [yī-shēng]-lǎo	(4) *yí gè lǎo
[NMLZ-teach]-PEJ	[sing-NMLZ]-PEJ	[cure-NMLZ]-PEJ	one CL PEJ
'teacher'	'singer'	'doctor'	

Semantic properties:

- the pejorative effects of -lǎo are unbounded (BEAVER & STANLEY 2022) (5);
- there is a separation of the pejorativity target and the resulting denotation of [X-lǎo];
- E.g., (2a) essentially expresses the speaker's negative opinions against *all fat people in general* and *fatness*, not just fat adult males; (2n²) disapproves *finance itself*, not just men in finance.

(5)# Wǒ cóngbù qíshì, dàn rúguǒ yǒu, nà wǒ bú huì hé nèi fat-lǎo wán.
1SG never discriminate but if have, then 1SG NEG will with that fat-PEJ play
'I have no discrimination, but if I did, I won't hang out with that fat-lǎo.'

Analysis

Syntactic Structure

- We argue that -lǎo expones a pejorative nominaliser, denoted n_{PEJ} (see 6);
- Notice that the occupation stems in (3) all contain an overt nominaliser, *lǎo*-, *-shǒu* and *-shēng*, so their incompatibility with -lǎo is expected;
- We attribute all the specifications in the objective meaning to n_{PEJ} , without positing separate layers like Gen^o;
- We leave as an open question whether a verb-/ adjective-becoming stem that merges with -lǎo with is categorised. There is a similar problem one encounters when analysing compounds.

(6) nP
 $e \rightarrow t$ $(e \rightarrow t) \rightarrow e \rightarrow t \blacklozenge (e \rightarrow t) \rightarrow t$
 n_{PEJ} $-lǎo$
 $\checkmark$
(7) $\llbracket n_{PEJ} \rrbracket = \llbracket n_{PEJ} \rrbracket^{obj} \blacklozenge \llbracket n_{PEJ} \rrbracket^{obj-cont}$, where
 $\llbracket n_{PEJ} \rrbracket^{obj} = \lambda P. \lambda x. \mathbf{R}(P)(x) \wedge \text{ADULT-MALE}(x);$
 $\llbracket n_{PEJ} \rrbracket^{subj} = \lambda P. \text{BAD}(\cap P).$
(8) $\llbracket (2n^2) \rrbracket = \llbracket n_{PEJ} \rrbracket(\llbracket \text{finance} \rrbracket)$
 $= \llbracket n_{PEJ} \rrbracket^{obj}(\llbracket \text{finance} \rrbracket) \blacklozenge \llbracket n_{PEJ} \rrbracket^{subj}(\llbracket \text{finance} \rrbracket)$
 $= \lambda x. \text{DO}(\lambda y. \text{FINANCE}(y))(x) \wedge \text{ADULT-MALE}(x) \blacklozenge \text{BAD}(\cap \lambda y. \text{FINANCE}(y)).$

Semantics

- The semantics of n_{PEJ} is of mixed type (see MCCREADY 2019);
- n_{PEJ} has two dimensions of contents, one objective and one subjective as seen in (7);
- The objective part (left to $\blacklozenge$) takes a property P and an individual x , requiring that a pragmatically determined relation $\mathbf{R}$ holds between P and x ;
- $\mathbf{R}$ can be BE, FROM, DO etc. (see INGASON & SIGURÐSSON 2020 i.a.);
- The subjective part (right to $\blacklozenge$) takes a property P and returns $\text{BAD}(\cap P)$ ($\cap$ denotes the kind operator (CARLSON 1977, CHIERCHIA 1998)), where pejorative effects arise.

Implications

- Mandarin -lǎo displays a clear case of *analytic pejorativity* as opposed to superficially monomorphemic pejoratives like *shrink*;
- Analytic pejorative affixes are also found in other languages, e.g. *-cayng-* in Korean;
- The study demonstrates the feasibility of a compositional analysis of pejorative expressions (for Potts in MCCREADY 2010 p. 10). It also provides a perspective on how discrimination can be linguistically represented in syntax and its interfaces with other modules.

References

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Abbreviations: 1 = first person, CL = classifier, COP = copula, NAME = name, NEG = negative, NMLZ = nominalizer, PEJ = pejorative marker, SG = singular.
I thank Yitong Luo, Jim Wood, Linmin Zhang, the students enrolled in LING240 at Yale during Fall 2024 and three anonymous reviewers for their comments.